

Sea lamprey

The sea lamprey is a jawless fish—instead of jaws it has a sucker filled with teeth, which it uses to feed on the blood of other fishes. It grows up as a larva in the rivers and lakes of North America and Europe, then lives its adult life in the salty North Atlantic Ocean, before returning to freshwater habitats to breed and die.

Northern waters

Sea lampreys can be found all across the North Atlantic, from the frigid waters of Greenland to the balmy latitudes of Spain and Florida, USA. While most adults live in the ocean, some make the Great Lakes of North America their home all year round.



Lamprey larvae

Sea lamprey eggs hatch into young called larvae. The larvae burrow into gravel on the riverbed, leaving their heads exposed. They filter feed on tiny particles swept into their mouth by tiny microscopic hairs called cilia. This larval phase can last for up to three years.



Feeding on blood

Adult lampreys clamp onto other fish with their sucker-like mouths to feed. They use their horny teeth and tongue to cut a hole in the prey's skin, swallowing its blood as food. The lamprey's saliva stops the blood clotting so it keeps flowing, often until the victim dies.



Toothy sucker

The round, jawless mouth is filled with rings of sharp teeth made from keratin, the same substance hair and horns are made from. Even the central tongue is rough for rasping.

Laying eggs

In summer, adult lampreys leave the ocean and swim upriver to breed. The female lays her eggs in nests made from sand or pebbles on the lake floor or riverbed.